

Bipartisan Campaign Messages are Credible Signals of Bipartisan Lawmaking *

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Abstract

Bipartisan cooperation is crucial for congressional productivity and democratic legitimacy, yet bipartisan campaign rhetoric is often dismissed as an electioneering tactic. If these appeals are simply “cheap talk,” they reveal little about how politicians govern, weakening the representational link between campaigning and lawmaking. We argue instead that campaign messages do credibly signal bipartisan intent, but that bipartisan lawmaking is concentrated in policy areas where candidates make bipartisan appeals. To test this theory of selective bipartisan lawmaking, we link policy-specific bipartisan campaign messages from U.S. House candidates (N=43,465; 2018–2022) to sponsorship and cosponsorship of related bills in the 116th–118th Congresses. We find that candidates who highlight bipartisan cooperation in specific policy areas while campaigning are also more likely to engage in meaningful cross-party policymaking and to achieve greater legislative success in those same domains in office. Our findings clarify the policy-specific structure of bipartisan lawmaking in a polarized era.

Keywords: Bipartisanship, Representation, Campaigns, Text-as-Data

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Bipartisan cooperation is both frequent and consequential in the United States Congress. Although congressional dysfunction dominates media and scholarly attention, cross-party collaboration remains a pervasive lawmaking approach. This cooperation drives policymaking success: members who approach lawmaking from a bipartisan lens tend to be more successful at advancing their bills through the legislative process, and most enacted laws secure cross-party support (e.g., Mayhew 1991; Curry and Lee 2020; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023). Bipartisan initiatives also generate greater public approval than partisan efforts, reinforcing confidence in Congress as an institution (e.g., Curry 2019; Wolak 2020). Cross-party cooperation thus serves as a cornerstone of congressional productivity and democratic legitimacy.

Given these stakes, congressional candidates have strong incentives to invoke bipartisanship on the campaign trail. Bipartisan rhetoric allows candidates to frame their policy goals as achievable within an increasingly polarized legislature by signaling a willingness to build the cross-party coalitions often necessary for legislative success. When such rhetoric corresponds with legislative behavior, campaigns provide credible signals of candidates' governing intentions. This correspondence is central to promissory representation: bipartisan appeals establish public commitments about how candidates propose to govern, and conduct in office reveals whether elected officials act in accordance with those commitments.

Bipartisan campaign messages, however, are widely regarded as unreliable signals of governing behavior. A variety of research suggests that bipartisan rhetoric is infrequent, even among legislators known for working across the aisle (e.g., Gutmann and Thompson 2014; Pew Research Center 2017; Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020; Kistner et al. 2025). When such messaging does occur, other work finds it inconsistently links to bipartisan legislative action (e.g., Westwood 2022; Crowder-Meyer 2025; Seghy 2025). These scholarly perspectives align with media accounts that portray bipartisan rhetoric as "cheap talk" and genuine collaboration as something lawmakers are reticent to highlight (e.g., Stein 2018; Berman 2019; Fitch 2025). Regardless of whether bipartisan cooperation is falsely advertised or deliberately concealed, the resulting gap between campaign messaging and legislative behavior has important consequences. When campaign appeals do not

reliably correspond to legislative behavior, elected officials fall short of their normative duty to make governing intentions clear and accountable (Mansbridge 2003).

We challenge this view by arguing that bipartisan campaign messages do credibly signal bipartisan lawmaking—specifically in the policy domains where candidates express them. Furthermore, we posit that these appeals are selective: legislators invoke cross-party collaboration when discussing some policy priorities but not others, and these appeals signal the domains in which legislators intend to pursue inter-party collaboration once in office. To evaluate these dynamics, we analyze policy messaging in U.S. House candidates’ campaign platforms from 2018 to 2022 ($N = 43,465$). We use a supervised machine learning pipeline to identify bipartisan appeals within these platforms. We then assess whether legislators exhibit greater cross-party collaboration in the policy domains associated with their bipartisan campaign appeals in the 116th–118th Congresses, operationalizing bipartisan engagement through bill sponsorship and cosponsorship patterns.

Our descriptive analyses support the expectation that bipartisan campaign messaging is both prevalent and selectively deployed. Nearly half of all incumbents—across ideological leanings and electoral contexts—incorporate bipartisan appeals into their campaign platforms. Most, however, confine these appeals to one or two policy domains. Across candidates, bipartisan appeals span a broad range of domains, including contentious areas such as healthcare and environmental policy. This uneven use within platforms suggests that candidates present bipartisanship as a policy-oriented signal rather than a general commitment to cross-party collaboration.

Using regression-based analyses, we examine (1) whether campaign commitments tied to candidates’ policy priorities signal cross-party lawmaking in relevant policy domains, and (2) whether bipartisan appeals correspond specifically to substantive participation in drafting and introducing bipartisan legislation. We estimate complementary random- and fixed-effects specifications. The former adjusts for established predictors of bipartisan behavior; the latter leverages within-legislator variation across policy areas in the same Congress. We find evidence of congruence between policy-specific bipartisan campaign statements and cross-party collaboration in relevant policy areas. The association is strongest and most consistent for substantive bipartisan engagement—specifically,

bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship, which are activities associated with developing and introducing legislation. Even among first-term members, whose appeals cannot describe collaboration already undertaken in office, bipartisan campaign messaging corresponds to substantive cross-party lawmaking. Finally, we show this collaboration is consequential: substantive bipartisan engagement is positively associated with the share of a legislator's policy-relevant bills that pass the House and become law.

These findings clarify the link between campaign rhetoric and legislative behavior. Bipartisan appeals—often characterized as absent from campaigns or dismissed as electioneering—credibly signal conduct in office. Whereas prior work evaluates promise-keeping through issue emphasis (see Sulkin 2009, 2011), we show that legislators signal their bipartisan legislative behavior during campaigns, specifically how they intend to legislate and with whom. Our findings suggest that politicians view bipartisanship strategically, as a powerful tool for achieving policy goals. They also challenge normative critiques that campaigns obscure rather than illuminate governing behavior. The campaign-to-Congress connection we document suggests that representatives fulfill their duty to align their bipartisan electoral commitments with their legislative conduct.

Our selective bipartisanship framework also reconciles an apparent tension in the literature: polarization dominates contemporary American politics, yet meaningful bipartisan cooperation persists. This framework shows that legislators cooperate selectively in policy domains where cross-party incentives align—consistent with Levendusky's (2023) observation that “it may not be possible to bridge the gap on every issue, but there are cases where compromise and coming together is possible, and finding those pathways is worthwhile” (p. 154). Rather than implying that broad depolarization is necessary for a productive legislature, our findings identify the policy-defined pathways through which cross-party cooperation remains viable. Representative democracy can function amid polarization—not through sweeping consensus, but through targeted commitments candidates attach to their policy priorities, where compromise advances their policymaking goals.

The Promise and Practice of Bipartisan Lawmaking

Theories of representation and related empirical work offer several accounts of why campaign promises may structure elected officials' behavior in office. Representatives may keep campaign promises because voters penalize broken promises (e.g., Matthieß 2020; Naurin, Soroka and Markwat 2019). Even if sanctions are uncertain, the perceived risk of electoral punishment from constituents can motivate promise-keeping (Tomz and Van Houweling 2009). Risk-averse legislators may also avoid deviation to preempt costs imposed by other attentive observers, including donors, campaign opponents, the media, and legislative partners (e.g., Arnold 1990; Bawn et al. 2012; Bernhard and Sulkin 2013). Campaign promises also carry normative force. As Mansbridge (2003) argues and Rehfeld (2009) clarifies, the promissory representative "has a 'normative duty to keep promises' quite apart from fearing the electoral sanction he or she is sure to face" (p. 220). Put differently, imperfect electoral sanctioning does not diminish the democratic significance of promise-keeping because accountability inheres in the public commitment itself and in the normative obligation that commitment imposes on representatives to follow through.

Within this promissory framework, the link between campaign commitments and legislative behavior is typically examined by asking whether legislators pursue the policy areas they prioritize as candidates. Previous research finds that candidates adopt clear policy priorities on the campaign trail (e.g., Sides 2006) and that legislators do actively pursue those priorities once in office (e.g., Sulkin 2009, 2011; Thomson et al. 2017). Issue emphasis, however, represents only one dimension of promissory representation. Campaigns communicate not only the policy domains candidates intend to prioritize, but also the positions they adopt and the manner in which they intend to pursue their goals. One feature of this intended approach is candidates' orientation toward bipartisanship—defined here as members working with the opposing party to develop and advance legislation.

This distinction is significant because issue emphasis alone provides only partial evidence of promise-keeping. Issue emphasis identifies the domains a candidate has committed to prioritize but leaves their approach to fulfilling those commitments unspecified. For example, a politician who campaigns on healthcare and subsequently works on that issue in Congress would be considered to

have fulfilled their campaign commitment under an issue-emphasis approach to promise-keeping (see Sulkin 2009, 2011). Yet a commitment to pursue healthcare can take many forms: a member may introduce messaging bills that sharpen partisan differences or build cross-party coalitions to advance reform. Given the pervasiveness of messaging legislation (see Lee 2016), distinguishing between these forms of legislative activity is especially important. Bipartisan campaign appeals speak directly to this distinction, generating expectations about whom candidates will work with and how they will pursue their stated priorities once in office, thereby distinguishing between forms of follow-through that issue emphasis alone treats as equivalent.

Whether lawmakers' bipartisan campaign commitments correspond to their lawmaking approach bears directly on both public expectations and the practical work of legislating. Public opinion research shows that Americans prefer bipartisan legislative processes and outcomes (e.g., Harbridge and Malhotra 2011; Noel 2016; Bauer, Harbridge-Yong and Krupnikov 2017; Curry 2019; Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020; Wolak 2020). Moreover, structural features of the U.S. system rarely give either party both the margins and internal cohesion needed to govern unilaterally (Mayhew 1991). As a result, legislation most often passes with broad cross-party support, even in today's polarized environment (Curry and Lee 2020), making bipartisan coalition-building central to legislative success. Consistent with these dynamics, Americans are twice as likely to favor politicians who compromise across party lines to advance legislation over those whose ideological rigidity limits policy gains (Gallup 2025). If campaign rhetoric does not reliably correspond to bipartisan legislative conduct, then politically consequential behavior falls outside the accountability relationship underpinning promissory representation (Mansbridge 2003).

Despite these stakes, existing research has not directly or comprehensively tested whether candidates' own bipartisan campaign appeals correspond to their lawmaking behavior. Related work nevertheless suggests this relationship may be tenuous. Drawing on historic accounts of compromise, Gutmann and Thompson (2014) argue that even legislators predisposed to cross-party collaboration avoid emphasizing compromise on the campaign trail because "a successful campaign strategy requires the opposite of a compromising mindset. It favors candidates who...condemn their

opponents' positions at every turn" (p. 160). Studies of bipartisan rhetoric in other communication venues lend further support to this account, finding that such appeals constitute only a small fraction of politicians' communications with the press and their constituents (Pew Research Center 2017; Kistner et al. 2025). Politicians may be reticent to explicitly state their intentions toward bipartisan lawmaking for fear of alienating primary electorates and activists, who can be less favorable toward compromise (Hopkins, Lendway and Sigler 2025; Crowder-Meyer 2025). However, Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong (2020) show that lawmakers overestimate these groups' resistance to bipartisan compromise and are consequently more cautious than public opinion warrants.

A second line of work finds that politicians' bipartisan reputations do not consistently correspond to bipartisan behavior in office. Dobson, Volden and Wiseman (2025) show that politicians portrayed in the media as bipartisan tend to be more effective lawmakers, but find no consistent association between those portrayals and bipartisan legislative activity. Westwood (2022) also finds no relationship between members' bipartisan appeals on the House floor and subsequent collaboration across party lines. These findings align with accounts that treat bipartisan messaging as electioneering rather than a reliable signal of lawmaking intentions. Multiple studies find that electoral vulnerability encourages lawmakers to overstate or obscure their actual records of bipartisan behavior (Woon and Kanthak 2019; Kim, Lin and Schnakenberg 2024; Seghy 2025). As Trubowitz and Mellow (2005) argue, "[p]oliticians 'go bipartisan' when political circumstances make it electorally profitable for them to reach across the aisle," suggesting that such appeals may be used to attract electoral support without reflecting a true commitment to advance policy goals through bipartisanship lawmaking.

When politicians campaign as partisans but work across the aisle in office, their rhetoric fails to convey the character of their legislative behavior. Conversely, when politicians promise bipartisan lawmaking but fail to act accordingly, their rhetoric misrepresents their governing intentions. In either case, these studies raise questions about whether campaign rhetoric reliably corresponds to legislative conduct and, by extension, whether campaign claims meaningfully connect electoral authorization to representation in office. Resolving this uncertainty requires examining whether

candidates who make bipartisan appeals participate in cross-party coalition-building.

We address this question in two ways. First, we directly test whether candidates' own bipartisan campaign statements align with their bipartisan lawmaking behavior in Congress. Second, we specify the behavioral benchmark against which we evaluate these commitments. As detailed below, our theory defines campaign-to-Congress correspondence in policy-specific terms: candidates should engage in cross-party collaboration within the same policy domains in which they invoked bipartisanship during the campaign.

Bipartisanship as a Policy-Specific Commitment

Bipartisanship is typically conceived as a “legislative style,” characterizing the extent to which a legislator engages with members of the opposing party. Under this conceptualization, some legislators are more disposed to cross-party collaboration than others. This tendency likely arises from legislator characteristics (e.g., Porter, Harden and Dobson 2025), district pressures (e.g., Harbridge and Malhotra 2011; Porter, Kakenmaster and Francis 2025; Seghy 2025), and institutional environments (e.g., Harbridge 2015; Case and Ommundsen 2024).

We argue that campaign appeals reveal a policy-specific orientation towards bipartisanship. Candidates may invoke cross-party cooperation in some policy domains but not others, indicating the areas where they are particularly willing to pursue a bipartisan lawmaking approach. This issue-oriented framework for conceptualizing bipartisanship reflects the practical constraints legislators face in policymaking. Bipartisan engagement is costly, requiring negotiation, strategic coordination, and sustained relationship-building with members of the opposing party, and lawmakers have limited time and resources to devote to these efforts (Curry and Roberts 2023; Victor 2025; Ommundsen 2025a). However, lawmakers have strong incentives to bear these costs because cross-party cooperation is often the most viable path to legislative success (Curry and Lee 2020; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023).

Given that bipartisan tactics help achieve policy goals, these constraints suggest that bipartisan appeals reflect purposeful decisions about how to allocate scarce collaborative capital. This expectation is consistent with Craig (2023), who suggests that policy alignment fosters bipartisanship,

as shared objectives make cooperation mutually advantageous for advancing policy. Accordingly, we anticipate that politicians *selectively* employ appeals to bipartisanship, directing these appeals toward a finite set of policy domains in which members are most motivated to achieve policymaking success. Multiple factors likely shape which policy domains attract these appeals. Politicians may make bipartisan promises on topics that are important to them, that their constituents prioritize, or that reflect their party's "must-pass" legislative priorities. Conversely, politicians may avoid such promises in policy domains where their constituents oppose cross-party compromise (Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020).

Despite the varied motivations underlying these choices, the observable implication for our theoretical framework remains the same: politicians deploy bipartisan campaign appeals selectively to signal their commitment to a collaborative lawmaking approach in a particular domain. From this perspective, the relevant question is whether a member's bipartisan appeals and bipartisan lawmaking covary across policy domains. This argument does not require bipartisan appeals themselves to cause subsequent collaboration. Candidates may make such appeals because they already intend to invest in cross-party lawmaking within particular domains. Publicly associating themselves with that approach may also reinforce those intentions by creating electoral, reputational, or normative costs for deviation. Whether appeals reveal prior intentions, reinforce them, or do both, the observable implication is the same: bipartisan campaign appeals should identify the policy domains in which legislators concentrate their cross-party engagement.

H1 Politicians exhibit greater bipartisan legislative engagement in policy domains where they employed bipartisan campaign appeals than in policy domains where they did not.

A null finding would be consistent with several alternative interpretations about the relationship between bipartisan campaign commitments and legislative behavior. First, bipartisan appeals may reflect a general legislative disposition, or the tendency to be bipartisan across all policy domains. Second, politicians may conceal their orientation toward collaboration during campaigns yet still govern collaboratively once in office. Third, politicians may invoke bipartisanship on the campaign

trail as an electoral tactic without pursuing it in their legislative work. Conversely, greater bipartisan engagement in policy domains where politicians pledged cross-party collaboration would suggest that these campaign appeals signal a legislator's policy-specific approach to lawmaking.

Cross-party cooperation can take multiple forms, ranging from substantive, serious collaboration to low-cost position-taking. Substantive bipartisan engagement involves meaningful participation in crafting legislation within cross-party coalitions (Curry and Roberts 2023). Such “workhorse” activities include developing bill content, negotiating compromises, and coordinating with stakeholders to prepare legislation for introduction. Yet bipartisan engagement can also occur after substantive drafting and negotiations are complete, serving primarily as an endorsement of the legislation (Koger 2003) or as a means for position-taking (Mayhew 1974; Kessler and Krehbiel 1996). Through this “show horse” approach, politicians can claim to have fulfilled their bipartisan campaign promises without undertaking the costly work of drafting and negotiation.

We contend that if politicians treat bipartisan campaign appeals as signals made strategically to advance legislative goals, they should engage in workhorse forms of collaboration. Substantive bipartisan labor is the form of cross-party engagement that meaningfully propels legislation toward passage (Curry and Roberts 2023). This is also the form of representation voters value most, as they prioritize substantive cooperation over symbolic gestures (Butler et al. 2023; Strickler 2024). Accordingly, we expect legislators to demonstrate greater substantive bipartisan involvement in policy domains where they make bipartisan appeals.

H2 Politicians exhibit greater substantive bipartisan legislative engagement in policy domains where they employed bipartisan campaign appeals than in policy domains where they did not.

We additionally examine lower-cost bipartisan engagement as a diagnostic of superficial congruence between campaigning and legislating. Evidence of “workhorse” engagement, coupled with little evidence of an association with “show horse” engagement, would weigh against an account in which candidates satisfy their commitments to bipartisan lawmaking through superficial gestures alone. It would also be consistent with the logic that these modes of engagement are not jointly producible: a legislator cannot embody both on the same piece of legislation.

Within our theoretical framework, bipartisan appeals highlight the policy domains in which lawmakers are most motivated to invest in cross-party collaboration and build the necessary coalitions to achieve legislative victories. Substantive bipartisan engagement should, therefore, correspond to more frequent legislative success in relevant policy domains. Conversely, if the benefits of bipartisan collaboration accrue to legislators generally (cf. Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023), greater substantive bipartisan engagement should not correspond to higher rates of bill passage or enactment in relevant policy domains.

H3 Politicians achieve greater legislative success in policy domains where they engage in substantive bipartisan collaboration than in policy domains where they do not.

Identifying & Measuring Bipartisan Behavior

In this section, we detail our strategy for measuring bipartisan behavior. We conceptualize bipartisanship as a selective approach to working, collaborating, and compromising with lawmakers of the opposing party. Using candidates' campaign agendas, we identify the policy domains in which they make bipartisan appeals, allowing us to evaluate congruence between campaigning and governing behavior at a level of specificity unavailable in existing work.

Bipartisan Messaging in Campaigns

To measure candidates' bipartisan campaign messaging, we analyze the campaign platforms on congressional candidates' websites. These sites provide unmediated statements of candidates' policy priorities (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2009). Because candidates strategically tailor website content (e.g., Case 2027; Porter, Treul and McDonald 2023; Case and Porter 2025; Bailey and Reese 2025), these platforms provide insight into campaign strategy rather than serving as static repositories or echoes of party-aligned positions. Website priorities also tend to align with those communicated through other venues (Xenos and Foot 2005; Sulkin, Moriarty and Hefner 2007). Unlike social media, campaign websites impose no length limits, allowing candidates to present policy agendas with greater breadth and depth.

We analyze a corpus of campaign platforms compiled by Porter, Case and Treul (2025), covering

candidates for the U.S. House of Representatives in the 2018, 2020, and 2022 elections. The dataset includes 75% of all major-party contenders who appeared on the ballot in primaries during these cycles ($N = 4,507$).¹ We assign each platform point to one of thirteen broad policy domains (e.g., healthcare or immigration), allowing us to identify which domains candidates frame in bipartisan terms.² The full list of thirteen policy codes is available in Appendix A.

We classify platform points as bipartisan using a supervised machine learning pipeline. The classifier learns from human-coded examples how bipartisanship is expressed and applies those patterns to the remaining platform points. To train and test the models, we manually labeled a random sample of 4,300 documents for bipartisan messaging. Coders assessed whether each text as a whole conveyed a willingness to work with members of the opposing party. We did not code moderate policy positions as bipartisan unless they explicitly committed to cross-party cooperation. We trained several models on 3,900 documents and selected the best-performing XGBoost classifier, which achieved an F1 score of 0.83 on a held-out sample of 400 documents—identifying most bipartisan appeals while producing relatively few false positives. Appendix B reports the coding instructions, inter-coder reliability assessments, and model performance details.

In Table 1, we present example platform points illustrating a range of bipartisan appeals made by incumbents. These appeals typically reference policy areas in general terms rather than specific legislative proposals.³ This pattern is consistent with prior work showing that campaign rhetoric often takes the form of broad appeals—for example, candidates presenting themselves as “champions for education” or “tough on crime” (Stokes 1992; Sides 2006; Sulkin, Moriarty and Hefner 2007; Sulkin 2009, 2011). The structure of these appeals aligns with our use of broad policy-domain classifications to locate bipartisan rhetoric within campaign agendas.

Validating text-to-measure pipelines is essential for establishing construct recovery (Park and Montgomery 2025). Appendix C presents three validation exercises for our measure of bipartisan

¹Platforms were collected immediately before each candidate’s primary election. These texts reflect overall campaign messaging, as campaign websites tend to remain stable across stages (Porter, Treul and McDonald 2023).

²For additional details on assignment and validation procedures, see Porter, Case and Treul (2025).

³Through manual review of all platform points identified as bipartisan by our machine learning classifier, we find that over half invoke bipartisan cooperation within a policy area without naming a specific legislative proposal. For transparency, the online replication materials include the platform-point text and hand-labeled categorizations.

Table 1: Example Campaign Platform Points Classified as Bipartisan

Candidate	Statement Text
Jimmy Panetta (D-CA, 2020)	“Jimmy is working with both sides of the aisle to promote environmental stewardship and fight for policies that protect the Central Coast.”
David McKinley (R-WV, 2018)	“David has been a bipartisan leader on a range of health care issues...has focused on building coalitions across party lines. David knows Obamacare is broken. He has voted to repeal Obamacare mandates and taxes...and is working to find a common-sense replacement.”
Tulsi Gabbard (D-HI, 2018)	“Tulsi has an F-rating from the NRA and a 0% rating by the Hawaii Rifle Association, and a 100% rating by the Brady Campaign. She is focused on building bipartisan solutions that can actually be passed into law, rather than using the issue as a partisan political football.”
Mike Bost (R-IL, 2022)	“Congress must work together to prevent the financial collapse of [Social Security and Medicare] by promoting bipartisan efforts to address systemic problems and ensure their longevity for future generations.”

Note: Policy domains were pre-assigned by Porter, Case and Treul (2025). Texts were intentionally selected to demonstrate variation in bipartisan messaging across parties, policy domains, and communication styles. Randomly selected documents for face validation are presented in Appendix Table C.1.

campaign appeals. First, we compare six randomly selected campaign platform documents with their model-generated classifications to assess face validity (Appendix Table C.1). Second, we report the 30 highest-weighted word features from the model (Appendix Table C.2). The prominence of terms such as “bipartisan,” “together,” and “aisle” indicates that the classifier recovers the intended construct. Third, we assess predictive validity by comparing rhetoric among incumbents in the expressly bipartisan Congressional Problem Solvers Caucus with that of other incumbents (Appendix Section C.1). Caucus members are significantly more likely to use bipartisan messaging and devote a larger share of their platforms to bipartisan themes ($p < 0.001$).

In Appendix Section D.1, we assess whether our measure of bipartisan appeals is distinct from issue moderation. Although candidates may use bipartisan appeals to signal centrist positions, our measure seeks to capture expressed commitments to cross-party cooperation rather than the ideological content of their policy positions. Indeed, as examples in Table 1 demonstrate, politicians may pair more extreme positions on policy with bipartisan appeals. To evaluate whether this distinction holds empirically, we calculate point-biserial correlations between our dichotomous

classification of bipartisan messaging and candidates' issue-specific moderation, measured using the issue-positioning indexes developed by Case and Porter (2025). The correlations are weak to null, suggesting that bipartisan appeals are not simply proxies for issue-specific moderation but instead capture a distinct dimension of rhetoric.

Bipartisan Lawmaking in Congress

To determine whether politicians fulfill their bipartisan campaign commitments, we examine whether their bipartisan engagement in office is concentrated in the policy domains where they made such appeals as candidates. We operationalize this correspondence using bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, defined as the introduction of a bill by a legislator and its formal endorsement by a colleague, respectively. These voluntary activities reveal the policy priorities members seek to advance, largely independent of party and agenda-setting pressures (Highton and Rocca 2005; Sulkin 2009, 2011).⁴ Because lawmakers cannot engage meaningfully on every policy domain, their sponsorship and cosponsorship decisions are necessarily selective, consistent with our account of bipartisan campaign appeals as domain-specific commitments. Moreover, bills with cross-party cosponsors are also more likely to advance through the legislative process (Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023), giving members incentives to seek or offer cross-party support to improve a bill's chances of becoming law (Curry and Roberts 2023; Craig 2023).

Yet not all sponsorship and cosponsorship behaviors signal equal commitment to bipartisan lawmaking. Bill introduction is particularly informative because it credibly signals substantive commitment to advancing specific policy priorities (Schiller 1995). Although members often draft legislation collaboratively, congressional rules permit only one sponsor per bill. Original cosponsorship identifies other members involved in the initial drafting process. Members who join a bill on the day it is introduced, known as original cosponsors, are recognized as committed partners in its development and often viewed as coequal coauthors. As Curry and Roberts (2023)

⁴Roll-call voting offers an alternative measure of bipartisan lawmaking (see Westwood 2022) but is constrained by agenda setting and party discipline. Most bills never receive a roll-call vote, and those that do may not reflect a legislator's own priorities (Cox and McCubbins 1993, 2005). These selection effects obscure legislators' proactive efforts to advance policy.

explain, bills with bipartisan original cosponsorships are “seen as a serious and bipartisan legislative effort by actors on the Hill, in part because it is a signal that legislators on both sides of the aisle collaborated to produce it” (p. 342). Following existing work (e.g., Curry and Roberts 2023, 2025; Porter, Harden and Dobson 2025), we therefore use bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship to measure substantive cross-party collaboration.

While each bill has one sponsor and few original cosponsors, it may attract numerous non-original cosponsors at any stage before a vote. Existing work characterizes these cosponsorships as “bandwagoning,” whereby members sign on after observing colleagues’ reactions and assessing a bill’s prospects (Kessler and Krehbiel 1996), or as low-cost position-taking (Koger 2003). We thus treat non-original cosponsorship as a less costly indicator of bipartisan engagement.

We use the Congress.gov API to compile data on all bill sponsorship and cosponsorship activity in the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses. We also gather timing information to distinguish original from non-original cosponsors. Finally, we rely on Congressional Research Service issue-domain classifications, which capture each bill’s primary subject matter. These codes align with our thirteen issue-domain classifications of campaign platforms, allowing us to compare bipartisan appeals with relevant legislative activity.⁵

Prevalence and Selectivity of Bipartisan Campaign Appeals

Before evaluating whether candidates’ bipartisan appeals correspond to cross-party legislative behavior on relevant policy domains, we establish that such appeals appear in campaign platforms. Claims that these appeals are infrequent often rely on evidence that is indirect, narrow in coverage, or removed from candidates’ own rhetoric. As a result, the prevalence of bipartisan messaging in congressional campaigns remains unresolved. Existing work also does not examine whether candidates vary their use of bipartisan appeals across policy domains. This variation is central to our framework: if candidates use bipartisan language uniformly across their agendas, it cannot signal selective collaboration. The descriptive analyses below address both prerequisites. First, we show that bipartisan appeals are common in campaigns. Second, we show that their use is selective, with

⁵Appendix A provides detail on the correspondence between campaign platform and legislative policy codes.

most candidates invoking bipartisanship on only one or two policy priorities. Across candidates, however, these appeals span the full range of issue domains in our data.

Bipartisan Messaging Across Candidates

We begin by assessing the prevalence of bipartisan messaging in the campaign platforms of candidates elected to the U.S. House. We classify a candidate as a bipartisan campaigner in a given cycle if any of their platform points contain bipartisan rhetoric. By this measure, bipartisan messaging is relatively common. About 45% of members elected between 2018 and 2022 employed such appeals, rising to 50% among incumbents seeking reelection.⁶

Next, we examine whether bipartisan messaging varies systematically across candidates. Prior work identifies two groups as especially likely to use such appeals: ideological moderates and candidates in competitive districts (Trubowitz and Mellow 2005; Rhodes and Albert 2017). Moderates may emphasize bipartisanship to reinforce their centrist brand, signaling that their positions reflect a commitment to cross-party cooperation. Candidates in competitive districts may likewise signal cross-party openness to broaden their electoral base in close races. If candidates communicate bipartisan intentions only under these conditions, then bipartisan messaging would represent a narrow electoral strategy rather than a general feature of campaign communication.

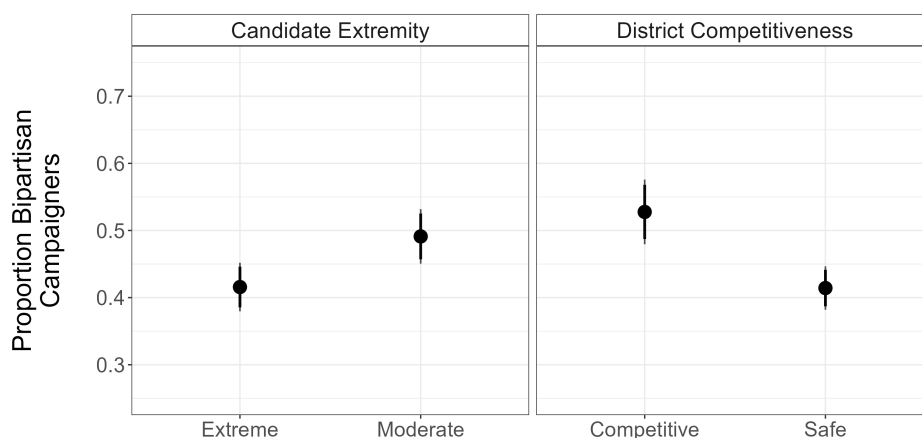
Figure 1 plots the share of bipartisan campaigners in the 2018–2022 elections by candidate extremity (left) and district competitiveness (right). We classify candidates as extreme (moderate) when the magnitude of their CFScore, calculated by Bonica (2024), exceeds (falls below) their party mean.⁷ Districts are classified as competitive when their average two-party presidential margin across the previous three elections is below 15 percentage points.⁸ We find that moderates are somewhat more likely than extreme candidates to adopt bipartisan appeals (49.5% versus 41.9%), as are candidates in competitive districts (52.8% versus 41.9%). Although t-tests indicate that these differences are statistically significant, adoption rates exceed 40% across every subgroup. Taken together, these patterns suggest that bipartisan messaging is not confined to particular candidate

⁶Appendix Table D.2 assesses predictors of bipartisan campaigner status among all major-party primary candidates.

⁷Stricter cutoffs (e.g., one-third of a standard deviation beyond the party mean) produce similar results.

⁸A 10-percentage-point cutoff produces substantively identical results.

Figure 1: Bipartisan Campaign Messaging by Candidate Ideology and District Competitiveness



Note: Units include all U.S. House general-election winners from 2018 to 2022. Bipartisan campaigners have at least one platform point containing a bipartisan appeal. Extreme (moderate) candidates have CFScores above (below) their party's mean. Competitive districts have an average two-party presidential margin below 15 percentage points across the previous three presidential elections. Vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

types or electoral contexts, but is instead broadly adopted in congressional campaigns.

Bipartisan Messaging Across Policy Domains

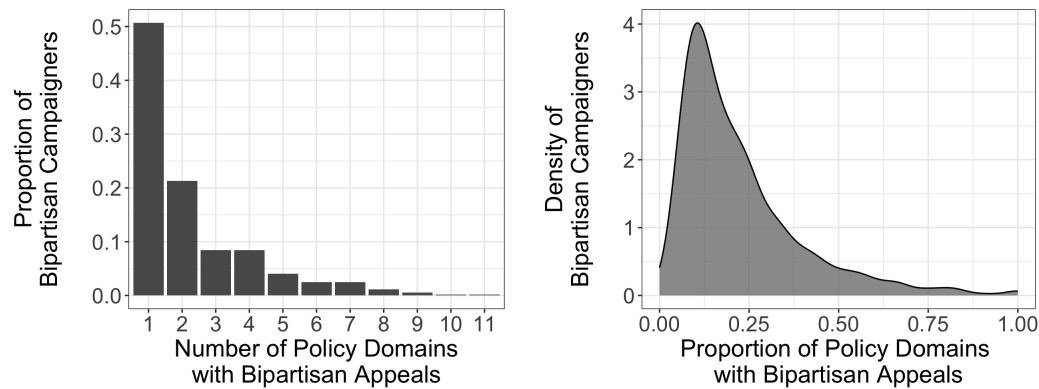
We next assess whether candidates vary their use of bipartisan messaging across policy domains. Reserving such appeals for only some domains in their campaign agendas indicates that bipartisan rhetoric serves as a targeted collaborative signal. To examine this selectivity, we focus on bipartisan campaigners, defined as general election winners who employ bipartisan rhetoric in at least one platform point. For these candidates, we examine all policy priorities and classify a policy domain as bipartisan if any corresponding platform point contains such rhetoric.⁹

Figure 2 shows the extent to which bipartisan campaigners incorporate such appeals into their platforms. The left panel reports the number of policy domains containing bipartisan appeals; the right panel standardizes this count by platform breadth. About half of bipartisan campaigners use such appeals on a single policy domain, and fewer than 15% extend them to more than half of their platform. Overall, we find that the broad use of bipartisan appeals is rare.

We next examine which policy domains candidates frame in bipartisan terms. Bipartisan messaging may be concentrated in distributive or consensus-oriented domains rather than those

⁹Candidates' platforms may include multiple platform points and several often address the same policy domain. If any of these points include bipartisan rhetoric, we consider the domain to be bipartisan.

Figure 2: Pervasiveness of Bipartisan Messaging in Campaign Platforms



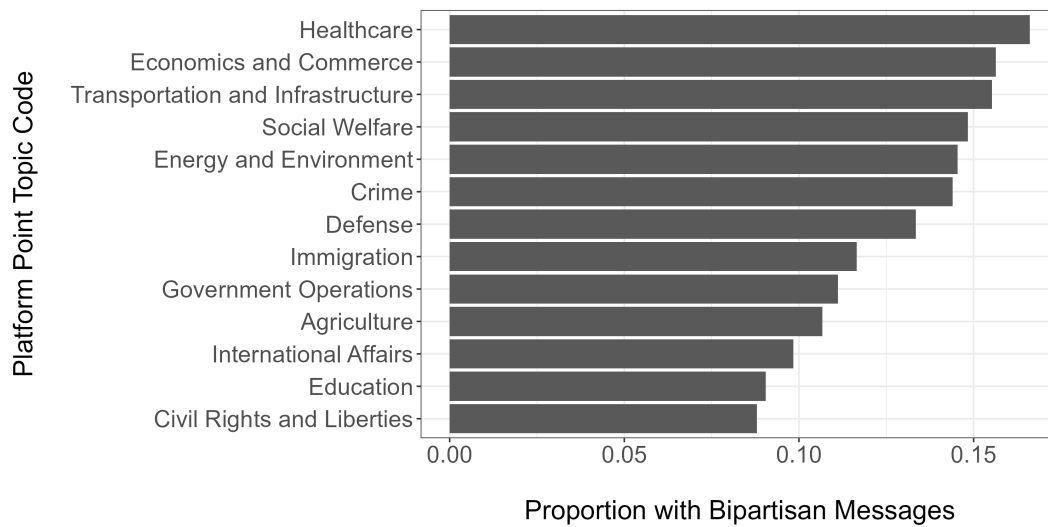
Note: Plots show the distributions of the number (left) and proportion (right) of policy domains in which candidates use bipartisan messaging. Bipartisan campaigners have at least one platform point containing a bipartisan appeal.

associated with partisan conflict. If so, these appeals would offer limited insight into legislative behavior in contentious domains, where cross-party collaboration is often most consequential for policy enactment. To evaluate this possibility, we examine how bipartisan messaging varies across the thirteen policy domains in our data. For each policy domain, we calculate the share of candidates who use bipartisan messaging, conditional on discussing that domain.¹⁰ Figure 3 plots the prevalence of bipartisan rhetoric by policy domain, ordered from highest to lowest. As expected, domains with frequent bipartisan engagement in Congress, such as the distributive area of *Transportation and Infrastructure*, show relatively high rates of bipartisan messaging (15.5%). Yet several contentious domains have comparable rates, including *Healthcare* (16.6%), *Energy and Environment* (14.5%), and *Crime* (14.4%). Even in the especially partisan domain of *Civil Rights and Liberties*, nearly 9% of candidates who discuss the issue use bipartisan appeals.

These analyses do not imply that all candidates make bipartisan appeals or that they do so in every context. Rather, they establish that candidates who win office are willing to communicate bipartisan intentions, even where prior work suggests such messaging should be uncommon. Individual candidates typically confine these appeals to a few policy domains, but across candidates they span a broad range of policy areas rather than cluster within a narrow set. This combination of prevalence and selectivity raises a central question about democratic representation and accountability: are

¹⁰Candidates are selective in issue emphasis, addressing an average of seven policy domains per election cycle.

Figure 3: Bipartisan Messaging in Campaign Platforms by Policy Domain



Note: Proportions are calculated among candidates who addressed a given issue area; the numerator is the number whose platform point(s) on that issue included bipartisan messaging.

candidates’ policy-specific bipartisan commitments associated with cross-party legislative action on the same issues once they take office?

Do Bipartisan Commitments Correspond to Cross-Party Lawmaking?

We test, for a given legislator in the given Congress, whether the use of bipartisan campaign rhetoric in a policy domain is associated with greater bipartisan activity in that domain than in other domains. If these appeals credibly signal collaborative priorities, cross-party cooperation should be greater in domains where legislators make such commitments. We first assess whether legislators sponsor and cosponsor a greater share of bipartisan bills in domains where they make bipartisan appeals, then determine whether this association holds for substantive “workhorse” collaboration. Observations are measured at the member–Congress–policy level, yielding thirteen per member–Congress (e.g., Elise Stefanik (R-NY)–116th Congress–*Immigration*).

Bipartisan Appeals and Legislative Engagement Across Policy Domains

To assess patterns of legislative activity, we examine members’ sponsorship and cosponsorship of bipartisan bills, which we term bipartisan bill engagement. We define a bipartisan bill as legislation with at least one Democrat and one Republican among its sponsor and original cosponsors.¹¹

¹¹Defining bipartisan bills using the sponsor and *any* cosponsors produces substantively identical results.

Because these members are substantive drafting partners (Curry and Roberts 2023), this definition identifies bills whose initial coalition was bipartisan. We measure bipartisan bill engagement as the share of a member’s sponsorship and cosponsorship activity within a policy domain involving bipartisan bills. This measure captures how members allocate their legislative efforts while accounting for variation in their overall volume of activity.¹² Our outcome captures realized bipartisan engagement rather than a legislator’s latent willingness to cooperate across party lines. Accordingly, a unit is coded zero when a legislator undertakes no relevant activity or when none of their activity involves a bipartisan bill as neither represents observable bipartisan engagement.¹³

Our key explanatory variable is a three-level factor capturing messaging in the previous election, with categories indicating whether candidates: (1) campaigned on the policy domain *with* bipartisan messaging, (2) campaigned on the domain *without* bipartisan messaging, or (3) *did not* campaign on the domain. Because politicians seek to fulfill campaign promises (Sulkin 2009, 2011), they may collaborate across party lines in any policy domain included in their platforms, not only those framed in bipartisan terms. Comparing the three categories allows us to determine whether bipartisan messaging carries predictive power independent of issue emphasis.

We employ two complementary modeling approaches. The first estimates random-effects models that adjust for observed characteristics associated with legislators’ general propensity for bipartisan lawmaking. Controls include district competitiveness, indicated by an average two-party presidential margin of 15 percentage points or less; legislator extremity, measured as the absolute DW-NOMINATE score standardized to mean zero and unit variance; indicators for prior elected experience, policy-relevant committee membership, gender, race, ethnicity, seniority, majority-party status, and party affiliation. We include policy-Congress fixed effects to account for agenda dynamics and cross-party coalition-building opportunities that vary across policy areas and over time, along with member-Congress random intercepts to capture differences in legislators’ general propensity for bipartisan lawmaking not accounted for by the observed covariates. This specification allows us

¹²Negative binomial regressions using count outcomes also produce similar results (Appendix Tables E.1–E.2).

¹³Replicating the analyses after excluding member-Congress-policy observations with no sponsorship or cosponsorship activity in the relevant domain produces substantively similar results (Appendix Tables F.1–F.2).

Table 2: Bipartisan Messaging & Legislative Engagement

	DV: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Bipartisan Messaging	−0.022*** (0.007)	−0.018*** (0.007)
No Messaging vs. Bipartisan Messaging	−0.019*** (0.007)	−0.015** (0.007)
Observations	14,846	14,846
Controls	✓	
Member-Congress RE	✓	
Member-Congress FE		✓
Policy-Congress FE	✓	✓

Note: OLS models with member-Congress-policy observations. Bipartisan bill engagement is the share of sponsored or cosponsored bills with at least one Democrat and one Republican among the sponsor and original cosponsors. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by member in the fixed-effects specification. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

to estimate how member-level characteristics relate to cross-party engagement and benchmark the bipartisan-messaging coefficient against other major predictors of such behavior.

The second approach uses member-Congress fixed effects to provide a stricter test of our theory. Whereas the random-effects models draw on comparisons both within and across legislators, this specification compares policy domains for the same legislator in the same Congress. Fixed effects absorb static and time-varying institutional and individual characteristics, including each member’s general propensity for bipartisan cooperation within a given Congress. We also retain policy-Congress fixed effects to account for changes in the legislative agenda and opportunities for cross-party cooperation within each policy area. We estimate all models using OLS, which permits comparable random- and fixed-effects specifications and yields coefficients interpretable as changes in the share of a legislator’s policy-specific activity devoted to bipartisan legislation. Our conclusions are unchanged across alternative specifications.¹⁴

Table 2 presents evidence consistent with H1; full results are available in Appendix Table H.1.¹⁵

In the random-effects specification, the share of domain-specific sponsorship and cosponsorship

¹⁴Fractional logit models better accommodate bounded outcomes but do not provide a random-effects specification. Replicating the fixed-effects analyses with fractional logit produces substantively equivalent results (Appendix G.1–G.2).

¹⁵The bivariate relationship is also consistent with expectations. Mean bipartisan bill engagement is 54.9% among member-Congress-policy observations with bipartisan campaign messaging, compared with 48.3% among observations with non-bipartisan messaging and 51.1% among those without campaign attention. The bipartisan-messaging category differs significantly from both comparison categories at the 0.01 level.

activity involving bipartisan bills is 2.2 percentage points higher in domains where legislators made bipartisan appeals than in domains they discussed without such appeals, and 1.9 points higher than in domains omitted from their platforms. These differences persist under member-Congress fixed effects, at 1.8 percentage points relative to domains discussed without bipartisan language and 1.5 percentage points relative to domains omitted from a candidate's platform.

The three-category comparison also distinguishes bipartisan framing from issue emphasis. Domains discussed without bipartisan appeals are statistically indistinguishable from domains omitted from campaign platforms altogether ($p = 0.41$).¹⁶ We find no evidence that discussing a policy domain in a campaign platform is associated with a larger share of bipartisan legislative activity; the informative distinction is whether the candidate explicitly discusses that policy domain in bipartisan terms. Bipartisan campaign appeals thus signal not only which issues legislators will pursue in office, but how—and with whom—they will pursue them.

Taken together, these results show that congruence between bipartisan campaign appeals and legislative behavior is modest in magnitude but present and consistent. Importantly, this relationship persists when policy domains are compared for the same legislator in the same Congress under the fixed-effects specification, a conservative and demanding test. Yet this aggregate measure of bipartisan activity leaves unresolved whether this congruence reflects substantive collaboration. Legislators may join cross-party coalitions after substantive work is complete, claim credit, and avoid the costs of collaboration. If bipartisan appeals reflect genuine collaborative intent, their association with legislative behavior should be concentrated in the activities that constitute substantive participation in drafting and introducing legislation, rather than in the low-cost engagement that occurs after a bill is written.

Bipartisan Appeals and Substantive Engagement Across Policy Domains

We next examine whether the relationship between bipartisan campaign commitments and legislative activity reflects substantive “workhorse” collaboration. We define substantive bipartisan bill engagement as sponsorship or original cosponsorship of a bipartisan bill, identifying legislators

¹⁶These contrasts re-estimate the fixed-effects model in Table 2 with omitted domains as the reference category.

Table 3: Bipartisan Messaging & Bipartisan Legislative Engagement by Engagement Type

	DV: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement			
	Sponsor/Orig.	Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.037*** (0.009)	−0.029*** (0.009)	−0.013 (0.008)	−0.008 (0.008)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.049*** (0.010)	−0.046*** (0.010)	−0.017** (0.008)	−0.013 (0.008)
Observations	14,846	14,846	14,846	14,846
Controls	✓		✓	
Member-Congress Random Effects	✓		✓	
Member-Congress Fixed Effects		✓		✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: OLS models with member-Congress-policy observations. Bipartisan bill engagement is the share of bills a legislator sponsors or cosponsors with at least one Democrat and one Republican among the sponsor and original cosponsors. Standard errors are reported in parentheses and clustered by member in the fixed-effects model. Full model results are available in Appendix H.2. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

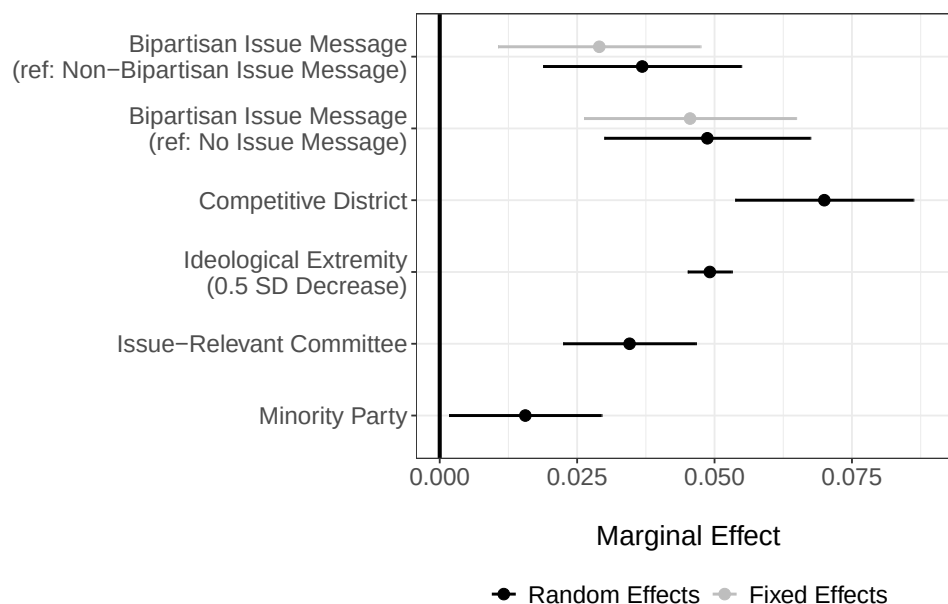
in the cross-party coalition responsible for its authorship and introduction. As an additional diagnostic, we test whether bipartisan campaign appeals correspond to “show horse” legislative engagement, which we define as non-original cosponsorship of bipartisan bills.¹⁷

Table 3 presents evidence consistent with H2; full results are available in Appendix Table H.2. Depending on the specification and comparison category, members devote between 2.9 and 4.9 percentage points more of their sponsorship and original cosponsorship activity to bipartisan bills in domains where they made bipartisan campaign appeals than in domains they discussed without such appeals or omitted from their platforms. Evidence for “show horse” engagement is more limited. Neither specification detects a difference in non-original cosponsorship between domains discussed with and without bipartisan messaging. The random-effects model indicates lower non-original cosponsorship in policy domains omitted from a candidate’s platform, but this difference is indistinguishable from zero under member–Congress fixed effects.

Aligning with our expectations, the most consistent evidence of a campaign-to-Congress connection appears in “workhorse” forms of collaboration. To place the magnitude of these relationships

¹⁷We again define bipartisan bills as those with at least one Democrat and one Republican among the sponsor and original cosponsors.

Figure 4: Contextualizing Bipartisan Messaging and Substantive Legislative Engagement



Note: Points show marginal effects on the share of sponsorship and original-cosponsorship activity involving bipartisan bills; bars show 95% confidence intervals. Black and gray estimates correspond to the random-effects and member–Congress fixed-effects models in Table 3. Member-level benchmarks are shown only for the random-effects model because member–Congress fixed effects absorb these predictors.

in context, Figure 4 compares the estimates for bipartisan messaging with the marginal effects of four established predictors of cross-party engagement from the random-effect models; fixed-effects estimates for the messaging contrasts are included for reference. Minority-party status captures these members’ heightened dependence on majority-party cooperation to advance legislation (Curry and Lee 2020). Issue-relevant committee membership captures the domain-specific opportunities for collaboration created by service on relevant committees (Harbridge 2015; Craig 2023; Victor 2025).¹⁸ Ideological moderation increases the policy overlap that makes cooperation with the opposing party possible (Rhodes and Albert 2017). District competitiveness strengthens legislators’ electoral incentives to cultivate cross-party appeal (Trubowitz and Mellow 2005; Seghy 2025).

The association between bipartisan campaign messaging and bipartisan legislative activity rivals that of established predictors. Depending on the comparison category, the association with bipartisan messaging is 53–70% as large as that of district competitiveness, 75–99% as large as that of a half-

¹⁸For example, a legislator serving on the House Agriculture Committee has relevant committee membership in the policy domain of agriculture. That service creates structured opportunities for cross-party collaboration on agricultural policy through hearings, markups, and bill development, but not comparable opportunities in other policy domains.

standard-deviation decrease in ideological extremity, 107-141% as large as that of issue-relevant committee membership, and 2.4-3.1 times as large as that of minority-party status. Taken together, the domains where candidates invoke bipartisanship predict cross-party collaboration as well as the electoral and institutional features conventionally used to explain such behavior.

Because our analysis is conducted at the policy-domain level, these results should be interpreted as evidence of correspondence between campaign policy priorities and legislative activity in the same domain. This level of aggregation reflects how candidates typically articulate bipartisan commitments as broad policy-area pledges. To assess whether the results depend on this level of aggregation, we replicate the main analyses using a subset of narrower policy areas. Appendix Tables I.1–I.2 report substantively similar results.

An additional question is whether this substantive engagement is directed toward policy priorities with meaningful constituency relevance. Legislators might participate in bipartisan coalitions on issues that carry few stakes for the communities they represent. We therefore examine whether the domains in which legislators engage in substantive bipartisan lawmaking are important to their districts. As Appendix Table J.1 shows, substantive bipartisan engagement is more common in domains with greater district importance. This pattern strengthens the interpretation that the activity we observe reflects substantive efforts to advance locally relevant policy priorities rather than bipartisanship pursued primarily for appearance’s sake.

Bipartisan Messages as Prospective Campaign Commitments

Our analyses thus far document three patterns: (1) candidates employ bipartisan campaign appeals selectively; (2) these appeals are associated with bipartisan legislative engagement in corresponding policy domains; and (3) they are associated with greater substantive, “workhorse” collaboration. A prospective interpretation of these patterns assumes that campaign messages convey information about behavior in the subsequent Congress. Among incumbents, however, the observed associations may instead reflect continuity with prior legislative activity. Incumbents may use bipartisan appeals to highlight earlier legislative achievements, while their subsequent activity may represent persistence in established behavior rather than the fulfillment of prospective commitments.

Table 4: Bipartisan Messaging & Substantive Legislative Engagement for First-Term Legislators

	DV: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.077** (0.038)	−0.070* (0.040)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.090** (0.039)	−0.089** (0.041)
Observations	2,496	2,496
Controls	✓	
Member-Congress Random Effects	✓	
Member-Congress Fixed Effects		✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: OLS models using member-Congress-policy observations. Bipartisan bill engagement is the share of bills a legislator sponsors or cosponsors with at least one Democrat and one Republican among the sponsor and original cosponsors. Standard errors are reported in parentheses and clustered by member in the fixed-effects model. Full model results are available in Appendix H.3. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

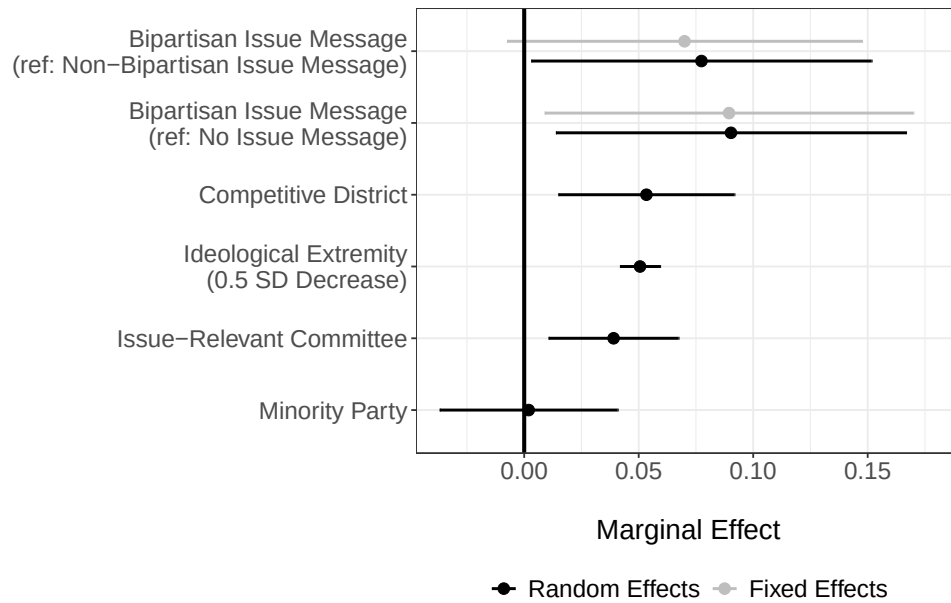
Members also draw on established relationships when assembling cross-party coalitions (Curry and Roberts 2023); accordingly, observed collaboration may reflect preexisting partnerships and norms of reciprocity as much as, or more than, campaign messaging.

To better isolate the prospective component of campaign messaging, we exploit the unique position of first-term legislators. Freshman members cannot invoke prior congressional accomplishments, removing retrospective credit-claiming as a potential explanation. The cross-party networks that facilitate bipartisan collaboration also develop through repeated interactions over multiple congressional sessions, social capital that freshmen have had little opportunity to accumulate (Ommundsen 2025b). Under these constraints, their campaign appeals provide clearer measures of ex ante commitments. If retrospective credit-claiming or established congressional networks drive our main results, the estimates should attenuate or disappear among freshmen.

We reestimate the substantive-engagement models reported in the first two columns of Table 3, restricting the sample to first-term legislators.¹⁹ Table 4 reports the truncated results, with full model results available in Appendix H.3. Our findings are consistent with prior results from Table 3. In

¹⁹Several members newly elected to the 116th, 117th, or 118th Congress had served in the House during an earlier, nonconsecutive Congress. Excluding these members yields identical results.

Figure 5: Contextualizing Bipartisan Messaging and Substantive Legislative Engagement of First-Term Legislators



Note: Points show marginal effects on the share of sponsorship and original-cosponsorship activity involving bipartisan bills; bars show 95% confidence intervals. Black and gray estimates correspond to the random-effects and member–Congress fixed-effects models in Table 4. Member-level benchmarks are shown only for the random-effects model because member–Congress fixed effects absorb these predictors.

the random-effects model, bipartisan campaign messaging is associated with 7.7 percentage points more substantive bipartisan engagement than non-bipartisan policy messaging and 9.0 percentage points more than no policy messaging. The corresponding fixed-effects estimates are 7.0 and 8.9 percentage points for non-bipartisan policy messaging and no policy messaging, respectively.

Figure 5 places the estimates for first-term legislators alongside the same four benchmarks as in Figure 4. Depending on the comparison category, the random-effects estimates for bipartisan messaging are 1.5–1.7 times as large as the association with district competitiveness, 1.5–1.8 times as large as the association with a half-standard-deviation decrease in ideological extremity, and 2.0–2.3 times as large as the association with relevant committee membership. Minority-party status has no discernible association with substantive bipartisan engagement in this subsample.

Substantive Bipartisan Engagement and Legislative Success

Our theoretical framework argues that politicians treat bipartisan campaign appeals as credible, selective commitments made instrumentally to advance legislative goals. This strategic orientation

Table 5: Legislative Success and Substantive Bipartisan Engagement

	DV: Proportion of a Legislator's Bill Engagement	
	Passed House	Becomes Law
Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	0.121*** (0.006)	0.067*** (0.004)
Observations	14,846	14,846
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

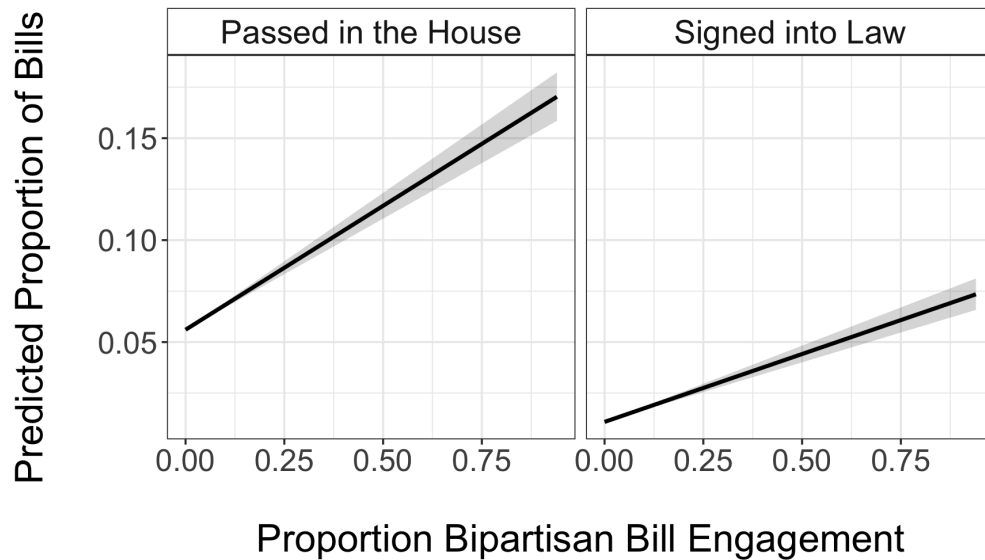
Note: Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Clustered standard errors by member. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

reflects the reality that bipartisan coalition-building is often necessary for lawmaking success. Indeed, existing work demonstrates that bipartisan cooperation is predictive of lawmaking success (e.g., Curry and Roberts 2023; Craig 2023; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023). These studies, however, focus on bipartisanship as a stable orientation towards lawmaking, rather than a policy-oriented commitment. If bipartisan appeals reflect instrumental calculations about achieving meaningful legislative success, the payoff should be observable at the policy-domain level.

To evaluate this component of our theory, we examine the relationship between substantive bipartisan engagement and policymaking success. Our key explanatory variable is the proportion of a legislator's substantive bill engagement in a policy domain that is bipartisan. As above, this measure captures the share of bills on which a legislator serves as sponsor or original cosponsor alongside at least one opposing-party member. The outcomes indicate, within each policy domain, the proportion of a legislator's sponsored or originally cosponsored bills that (1) passed the House or (2) became law. We estimate OLS regressions with the same fixed effects used above.

Table 5 presents the model estimates, which are consistent with H3. Increases in a legislator's substantive bipartisan bill engagement are associated with higher proportions of their initiatives passing the House (left column) and being signed into law (right column) within that policy domain. In other words, as the proportion of a legislator's bill engagement becomes more bipartisan—that is, as a larger share of their substantive bill engagement is bipartisan—they experience greater policymaking success within that policy domain.

Figure 6: Predicted Legislative Success Across Levels of Substantive Bipartisan Engagement



Note: Predicted values reflect within-member-Congress comparisons across issues based on the proportion of substantive bill engagement that is bipartisan, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Shaded regions indicate 95% confidence interval.

To interpret these results, Figure 6 displays the change in the predicted proportion of a legislator's policy-domain-related bills that pass the House (left panel) and become law (right panel) as a function of the proportion of relevant bipartisan bill engagement. Predicted values are generated holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Both panels show a clear upward trajectory: as legislators devote a larger share of their policy-domain-related engagement to bipartisan collaboration, the likelihood that their bills advance through the legislative process increases. These patterns are consistent with the idea that engaging substantively with members of the opposing party facilitates coalition formation, increases legislative viability, and ultimately improves the prospects of bill passage and enactment. Taken together, these findings indicate that bipartisan engagement is associated with greater policymaking success in the policy domains aligned with legislators' campaign commitments, aligning with our theoretical expectations.

Conclusion

Do candidates invoke bipartisan commitments during campaigns, and do these messages correspond to bipartisan lawmaking behavior? This paper provides evidence that campaign commitments

function as credible signals of bipartisan collaboration, deepening our understanding of representation in contemporary American politics. We introduce a novel theoretical perspective on bipartisanship, viewing it as a selective, policy-oriented commitment. This conceptualization has broad implications for how we understand candidate strategy in elections and the nuances of legislative follow-through. To test our theory, we connect virtually all available campaign platforms for U.S. House elections from 2018 to 2022 with legislative actions taken in the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses. This effort involved the supervised machine learning classification of 43,465 campaign statements and the collection of comprehensive data on legislative activity related to 28,648 introduced bills. Our approach therefore explores a previously unexamined dimension of campaign-to-Congress correspondence: whereas prior work shows that campaign agendas anticipate the policy priorities legislators pursue, we provide evidence that campaign messages also reveal the coalitional strategies they employ to advance those priorities in office.

Our findings demonstrate that bipartisan campaigning is common among candidates but is employed selectively within campaigns. About half of incumbents include bipartisan appeals in their platforms, but—consistent with our expectation that bipartisanship serves as a targeted messaging strategy—candidates typically focus these appeals on select policy domains. These findings add to an expanding body of research highlighting important nuances in how congressional candidates position themselves during campaigns (e.g., Case 2027; Case and Porter 2025; Bailey and Reese 2025). Future research should explore the complex calculations underlying these patterns, including how candidates decide which issues to frame in bipartisan terms, why certain policy areas tend to attract more cross-party appeals, and how electoral contexts influence these strategic decisions. The policy-driven and nuanced nature of bipartisan messaging offers valuable opportunities for scholars to analyze the micro-level strategic choices that determine when and how candidates call for cross-party cooperation during campaigns.

We find that legislators who make bipartisan appeals in specific policy domains during campaigns engage in cross-party collaboration within those same areas. Disaggregating across types of collaboration, we demonstrate that bipartisan campaign messaging predicts substantive bipartisan

action—bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship with colleagues across the aisle—rather than lower-cost, non-original cosponsorship. This “workhorse” pattern of collaboration persists even among first-term legislators who cannot claim credit for past bipartisan work or rely on established cross-party relationships, increasing confidence in the observed association. These findings underscore the importance of examining various forms of cross-party engagement.

Our findings address key questions about representation and democratic accountability in American politics. There are two established perspectives on the link between bipartisan campaigning and governance: one argues that politicians avoid discussing compromise during elections, making their campaign messages unreliable indicators of legislative behavior; the other considers bipartisan appeals to be cheap talk aimed at influencing specific voters. We find support for neither conception. Our analyses, instead, show a clear link between campaign promises and legislative action.

These findings carry significant implications for democratic theory and representative government. By demonstrating that bipartisan campaign appeals correspond to legislative behavior, this research affirms a central premise of promissory representation: campaign commitments are not merely electoral claims, but public obligations that elected officials are normatively expected to honor in office (Mansbridge 2003; Rehfeld 2009). This link is particularly consequential amid heightened polarization, where scholars have questioned whether campaigns illuminate or obscure the prospects for collaborative lawmaking. Our evidence challenges pessimistic accounts that bipartisan campaign rhetoric is purely strategic positioning divorced from governing conduct. Instead, we show that bipartisan commitments retain representative force in Congress, structuring the policy domains in which legislators engage in cross-party collaboration. Polarization, then, has not severed the campaign-to-Congress connection. Even within a deeply divided legislature, elected officials appear to act in ways consistent with the cooperative commitments they make on the campaign trail. Understanding these dynamics is essential for assessing the health of American democracy because democratic legitimacy depends not only on electoral competition, but also on whether representatives carry their public commitments into the exercise of governing authority.

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Bipartisan Campaign Messages Are Credible Policymaking Commitments

Supporting Information

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A Topical Coding Correspondence & Descriptives

Major Policy Topic	Corresponding CRS Policy Area
Agriculture	Agriculture and Food
Civil Rights, Liberties, and Minority Issues	Civil Rights and Liberties, Minority Issues; Native Americans (Note: statements about abortion may fall under the "Health" MPT)
Crime	Crime and Law Enforcement (Note: statements about terrorism may fall under the "International Affairs" MPT)
Defense	Armed Forces and National Security (Note: statements about alliances and international affairs may fall under the "International Affairs" MPT)
Economics and Commerce	Economics and Public Finance; Commerce; Finance and Financial Sector; Taxation; Foreign Trade and International Finance (Note: statements about the national budget may fall under the "Government Operations" MPT; statements about international trade may fall under the "International Affairs" MPT)
Education	Education
Energy and Environment	Energy; Environmental Protection; Public Lands and Natural Resources
Government Operations	Congress; Government Operations and Politics
Immigration	Immigration
Healthcare	Health
International Affairs	International Affairs (Note: statements about trade may fall under the "Economics and Commerce" MPT)
Social Welfare	Housing and Community Development; Social Welfare
Transportation and Infrastructure	Transportation and Public Works; Water Resources Development (Note: statements about water quality and environmental issues may appear under the "Energy and Environment" MPT)

B Supervised Machine Learning Model Setup

B.1 Instructions for Coders

Three undergraduate research assistants (RAs) and one principal investigator (PI) hand-labeled campaign messages for the presence or absence of bipartisan messaging. The following instructions were given to each of the coders:

Code as “1” if the statement advocates for bipartisanship or working across the aisle and “0” if not. If there is any mention of bipartisanship (even just one), code as 1. The following includes (but is not limited to) what qualifies as bipartisan messaging:

- Expressed commitment and willingness to work with the other party.
- Discussion of previous work or legislation that was bipartisan or worked across party lines
- Openness to engage with the other party
- Highlighting the need to come together to solve collective problems

B.2 Inter-coder Reliability Metrics

The RAs and PI labeled an initial practice set of 100 statements to ensure consistency across coders. After the initial practice set, 4,300 documents were randomly selected for hand-labeling. The undergraduate RAs labeled 1,000 documents each, and the PI labeled 2,000 documents. Within the hand-labeled set, 250 platform points were labeled by all four coders to assess inter-coder reliability. Table B.1 displays the percent agreement between each of the four coders, and Table B.2 displays the pair-wise Cohen’s Kappa. Across both tables, there is an extremely high level of reliability between coders. The RA and PI classification coding also track closely.

Table B.1: Hand-Labeled Percent Agreement

	PI	RA1	RA2	RA3
PI	–			
RA1	98.8%	–		
RA2	98.8%	98.4%	–	
RA3	97.6%	97.2%	97.2%	–

Table B.2: Cohen’s Kappa

	PI	RA1	RA2	RA3
RA1	0.851	–		
RA2	0.863	0.792	–	
RA3	0.757	0.682	0.705	–

B.3 Text Pre-Processing

We take the steps outlined below to pre-processing text from our corpus of platform points drawn from Porter, Case and Treul (2025):

- All text to lowercase
- String pattern ‘medicare for all’ to ‘medicareforall’
- String pattern ‘medicare-for-all’ to ‘medicareforall’
- String pattern ‘pro choice’ to ‘prochoice’

- String pattern ‘pro-choice’ to ‘prochoice’
- String pattern ‘pro-life’ to ‘prolife’
- String pattern ‘de-escalation’ to ‘deescalation’
- String pattern ‘dodd-frank’ to ‘doddfrank’
- String pattern ‘k-12’ to ‘ktwelve’
- String pattern ‘k12’ to ‘ktwelve’
- String pattern ‘pre-k’ to ‘prek’
- String pattern ‘4-year’ to ‘four year’
- String pattern ‘4 year’ to ‘four year’
- String pattern ‘2-year’ to ‘two year’
- String pattern ‘2 year’ to ‘two year’
- String pattern ‘non-violent’ to ‘nonviolent’
- String pattern ‘2nd amendment’ to ‘second amendment’
- String pattern ‘2a’ to ‘second amendment’
- String pattern ‘non-profit’ to ‘nonprofit’
- String pattern ‘non-discrimination’ to ‘nondiscrimination’
- Replace all ‘-’ with ‘ ’
- Remove all non-alphabetic characters
- Remove extraneous UTC code
- Trim white space

After preprocessing, we transformed the text into a term frequency–inverse document frequency (tf-idf) matrix, which weights words by their relative distinctiveness across documents. This tf-idf representation served as the feature input for our supervised learning models.

B.4 Model Parameter Selection

Of the 4,300 documents coded, we reserved 400 as a held-out test set to evaluate model performance, discussed in greater detail below. Before training our final models, we carried out a grid search to identify the set of hyperparameters that maximized performance under five-fold cross-validation on our 3,900 training documents. Grid search is a standard hyperparameter optimization procedure that systematically explores the parameter space to identify specifications that maximize out-of-sample performance. Table B.3 reports the full range of algorithms and parameter values we considered, with the selected values in bold.

B.5 Alternative Model Performance

We trained seven supervised classifiers—support vector machine, decision tree, random forest, gradient boosting, lasso, ridge, and XGBoost—on our hand-coded training data. This allows us to select the model that best captures the features of the data that are predictive of bipartisan messaging.

Table A4 reports out-of-sample performance across accuracy, precision, recall, and F1. Because our task involves identifying relatively rare instances of bipartisan rhetoric, the F1 score—which balances precision and recall—is especially informative. While several models perform well on accuracy alone, XGBoost attains the highest F1 (0.885) alongside strong accuracy (0.985) and recall (0.852), justifying its use as the primary classifier in the main analysis.

Table B.3: Model Tuning Parameters

Model	Tuning Parameter	Values
Support Vector Machine	Regularization	0.1, 1 , 10, 100
	Gamma	1 , 0.1, 0.01, 0.001
	Kernel	linear , rbf
Decision Tree	Max Depth	None, 10, 20 , 30
	Min Samples Split	2 , 5, 10, 20
	Min Samples Leaf	1 , 2, 4, 8
Random Forest	# Estimators	50, 100, 200, 300
	Max Depth	None, 10 , 20, 30
	Min Samples Split	2, 5, 10, 20
Gradient Boosting	# Estimators	50, 100, 200
	Learning Rate	0.01, 0.1 , 0.2
	Max Depth	3, 5 , 7
Lasso Regression	Regularization	0.01, 0.1 , 1, 10, 100
Ridge Regression	Regularization	0.01, 0.1, 1, 10 , 100
XGBoost	# Estimators	50 , 100, 200
	Learning Rate	0.01, 0.1, 0.2
	Max Depth	3, 5, 7
	Scale Position Weight	1, 2 , 5

Table B.4: Out-of-Sample Model Accuracy Statistics

Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1 Score
SVM	0.950	0.684	0.481	0.565
Decision Tree	0.960	0.762	0.593	0.667
Random Forest	0.948	0.875	0.259	0.400
Gradient Boost	0.978	0.950	0.704	0.809
Lasso	0.973	0.900	0.667	0.766
Ridge	0.945	0.619	0.481	0.542
XGBoost	0.980	0.952	0.741	0.833

C Bipartisan Messaging Measurement Validation

Table C.1: Random Selection of Classified Platform Documents

Candidate Name	Classification	Statement Text
Levii Shocklee	1	Quality, affordable health care is a right and should be available for ALL Americans. I intend to work, in a bipartisan fashion, to ensure that the citizens of the 6th district are heard regarding Health Care. I will work to ensure that the cost of health care is reduced for individuals and families struggling with high premiums as well as making sure that no one loses their insurance coverage.
Sanford Bishop	1	Tax relief is vital to encouraging economic growth. Congressman Bishop believes that tax relief is a bi-partisan issue and has routinely crossed the aisle to do what is best for American families. For example, he strongly supported the extension of the 2001 and 2003 tax cuts, which lowered tax rates across the board for all Americans and propelled the economic growth we experienced through most of the last decade.
Stephen Fanelli	1	A secure and safe border is one of the first duties of government in order to protect against disease, terrorism, and illegal incursion. While the Democrats promote open borders, I will sponsor legislation to secure our southern border immediately as well as reach across the aisle to find areas of agreement on improving the legal immigration process.
Justin Livingston	0	If you live in the Second District, the federal government, which owns over 50% of the land in the district, is your neighbor and it's often a pretty bad one. The U.S. Forest Service and Bureau of Land Management need a priority shift to allow more fuel reduction to prevent forest fires and employ loggers and millworkers throughout the Second District.
Joanne Wright	0	I believe life begins with a heartbeat. I believe we need to do more to educate women and provide birth control to women who do not want to get pregnant. I will fight against third trimester abortions. I believe partial birth abortions should be banned for the babies and the sake of the parents. Baby parts profiteering.
Jeremy Massengale	0	I believe that all of our natural rights including the one upheld in the 2nd amendment have been slowly eroded away. Wendell Phillips once said, "Eternal vigilance is the price of liberty; power is ever stealing from the many to the few." I believe we cannot give one inch when it comes to gun control. Every citizen has the right to defend his or herself. We must be ever vigilant with all of our rights.

Table C.2: XGBoost 30 Most Heavily Weighted Features (Words)

Words
bipartisan, sometimes, sides, together, start, aisle, expanding, promise, promised, local, day, party, lines, victims, aspects, requires, partisan, self, jobs, stronger, parties, prevent, gun, joined, trump, market, actually, capacity, colleagues, within

C.1 Predictive Validity in Bipartisan Messaging

The Problem Solvers Caucus aims to bring together Members of Congress through a shared commitment to bipartisanship. We expect that caucus members should, on average, engage in more bipartisan campaigning than their non-caucus counterparts. Consistent with this expectation, we find that 61.3% of caucus members engage in bipartisan campaigning, compared to only 43.2% of incumbents not in the caucus (diff = 18.1%; p-value < 0.001). Additionally, caucus members allocate a larger portion of their campaign platforms to bipartisan rhetoric than non-caucus incumbents (diff = 7.5%; p-value < 0.001). These results suggest that our supervised machine learning pipeline captures bipartisan messaging in theoretically expected ways.

D Additional Descriptive Analyses

D.1 Issue-Specific Moderation & Bipartisan Messaging

We evaluate whether our measurement captures bipartisanship as a distinct construct or functions as a proxy for ideological moderation. It may be that bipartisan appeals function chiefly as proxy indicators of *issue-specific moderation*, consistent with research documenting issue-by-issue variation in ideological positioning (e.g., Broockman 2016; Case and Porter 2025). To address this concern, we correlate measures for candidates' issue-specific moderation, developed by Case and Porter (2025), with our dichotomous classification of bipartisan messaging.¹ These candidate positioning indexes, or CPIs, capture the left–right positioning of incumbents and challengers across various issue areas using text from campaign websites.² Strong negative correlations would suggest that bipartisan issue messaging is associated with issue-specific moderation. The correlations are presented in Table D.1, however, indicate only weakly negative associations. The largest correlations are for *Guns* (-0.095) and *Healthcare* (-0.086), which are relatively small, with all other correlations approaching zero. These findings suggest that issue-level bipartisan appeals are not proxies for issue-specific or aggregate ideological moderation, but instead reflect a distinct dimension of candidate rhetoric.

¹The issue areas in Case and Porter (2025) do not perfectly align with our classification; we include all nominally aligned categories to maximize the breadth of this validation exercise.

²Because CPIs and our measure derive from the same underlying data, correlations are likely upwardly biased.

Table D.1: Issue-Specific Bipartisan Messaging and Moderate Issue Positioning

Campaign Platform Policy Topic (CPI Policy Topic)	Correlation
Civil Rights and Liberties (Abortion)	-0.063
Education (Education)	-0.031
Energy and Environment (Energy)	-0.060
Guns (Guns)	-0.095
Healthcare (Healthcare)	-0.081
Immigration (Immigration)	-0.080

Note: Topical categories do not align perfectly; we link them based on their closest substantive match. Correlation calculations include all candidates who addressed a given issue in their campaign platform for a given year.

Table D.2: Predictors for Bipartisan Campaign Messaging in Primary Elections, 2018–2022

	Dependent variable: Bipartisan Campaigner	
Competitive District	0.326*** (0.101)	0.337*** (0.107)
Incumbent MC	1.549*** (0.204)	1.476*** (0.205)
State Legislator	0.093 (0.230)	0.074 (0.232)
Amateur Politician	0.040 (0.187)	0.190 (0.188)
Pre-Primary Fundraising (Logged)	0.068*** (0.013)	0.094*** (0.024)
Female	0.043 (0.100)	-0.013 (0.105)
Republican	-1.101*** (0.100)	-1.022*** (0.115)
Contested Primary Election	-0.168 (0.105)	-0.252** (0.107)
Non-Partisan Primary	0.039 (0.124)	0.117 (0.130)
Ideological Extremity: WEB Score	-1.125*** (0.106)	
Ideological Extremity: CFScore		-0.429*** (0.126)
Constant	-1.095*** (0.265)	-1.841*** (0.381)
Year Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Observations	4,507	3,880

Note: Observations differ across models due to disparities in coverage across measures of ideological extremity. Clustered standard errors by candidate and congressional race. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

E Replication of Main Analysis Using Bipartisan Bill Counts

Table E.1: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through (Count)

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent Variable:
	Count of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.016 (0.023)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.216*** (0.025)
Observations	14,833
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: Model specification is a negative binomial model. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Bipartisan bill engagement measures the count of bipartisan bills sponsored or cosponsored. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table E.2: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through by Type of Bipartisan Engagement (Count)

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent variable:	
	Count of Bipartisan Bill Activity	
	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.074** (0.038)	0.011 (0.019)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.378*** (0.040)	−0.141*** (0.021)
Observations	14,833	14,833
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: Model specification is a negative binomial model. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

F Replication Excluding Observations with No Bill Activity

Table F.1: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through, Excluding Observations with No Bill Activity

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent Variable:
	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.018*** (0.007)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.009 (0.006)
Observations	14,611
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: Model specification is OLS. Unit are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Bipartisan bill engagement measures the proportion of bipartisan bills sponsored or cosponsored. Models exclude member-Congress-policy observations with no bill activity. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table F.2: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through by Type of Bipartisan Engagement, Excluding Observations with No Bill Activity

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent variable:	
	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.034*** (0.009)	−0.008 (0.007)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.034*** (0.010)	−0.007 (0.008)
Observations	13,677	14,611
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: Model specification is OLS. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Models exclude member-Congress-policy observations with no bill activity. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

G Replication of Main Analysis Using Fractional Logit

Table G.1: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through (Fractional Logit)

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent Variable:
	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.080*** (0.031)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.065** (0.032)
Observations	14,846
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: Model specification is fractional logit. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Bipartisan bill engagement measures the proportion of bipartisan bills sponsored or cosponsored. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table G.2: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through by Type of Engagement (Fractional Logit)

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent variable:	
	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.133*** (0.046)	−0.037 (0.036)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.207*** (0.048)	−0.060 (0.039)
Observations	14,846	14,846
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: Model specification is a fractional logit. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

H Full Main Paper Results

Table H.1: Bipartisan Messaging & Legislative Engagement

	DV: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Bipartisan Messaging	−0.022*** (0.007)	−0.018*** (0.007)
No Messaging vs. Bipartisan Messaging	−0.019*** (0.007)	−0.015** (0.007)
Competitive District	0.057*** (0.008)	
Ideological Extremity	−0.105*** (0.004)	
Pre-Congress Elected Experience	−0.003 (0.007)	
Issue-Relevant Committee	−0.012*** (0.004)	
Female	−0.008 (0.007)	
Black	−0.025** (0.010)	
Latino	−0.010 (0.011)	
Seniority	0.000 (0.001)	
Majority Party	−0.029*** (0.006)	
Republican	0.100*** (0.008)	
Constant	0.610*** (0.016)	
Observations	14,846	14,846
Member-Congress RE	✓	
Member-Congress FE		✓
Policy-Congress FE	✓	✓

Note: OLS models with member-Congress-policy observations. Bipartisan bill engagement is the share of sponsored or cosponsored bills with at least one Democrat and one Republican among the sponsor and original cosponsors. Standard errors are in parentheses and clustered by member in the fixed-effects specification. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table H.2: Bipartisan Messaging & Substantive Legislative Engagement for First-Term Legislators

	Dependent Variable: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.077** (0.038)	−0.070* (0.040)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.090** (0.039)	−0.089** (0.041)
Competitive District	0.053*** (0.020)	
Ideological Extremity	−0.101*** (0.009)	
Pre-Congress Elected Experience	−0.008 (0.018)	
Issue-Relevant Committee	0.039*** (0.014)	
Female	−0.012 (0.019)	
Black	−0.070** (0.029)	
Latino	0.004 (0.027)	
Majority Party	−0.002 (0.020)	
Republican	0.123*** (0.024)	
Constant	0.325*** (0.054)	
Observations	2,496	2,496
Member-Congress Random Effects	✓	
Member-Congress Fixed Effects		✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: Models are estimated using OLS and include only first-term legislators. Standard errors in the fixed-effects model are clustered by member. Fractional logit specifications for the fixed-effects model are available in the Appendix and produce statistically and substantively similar results. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table H.3: Bipartisan Messaging & Bipartisan Legislative Engagement by Engagement Type

	Dependent Variable: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement			
	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor		Non-Original Cosponsor	
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.037*** (0.009)	−0.029*** (0.009)	−0.013 (0.008)	−0.008 (0.008)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.049*** (0.010)	−0.046*** (0.010)	−0.017** (0.008)	−0.013 (0.008)
Competitive District	0.070*** (0.008)		0.044*** (0.008)	
Ideological Extremity	−0.098*** (0.004)		−0.096*** (0.004)	
Pre-Congress Elected Experience	−0.001 (0.007)		0.006 (0.007)	
Issue-Relevant Committee	0.035*** (0.006)		0.002 (0.005)	
Female	−0.009 (0.008)		−0.001 (0.008)	
Black	−0.017 (0.011)		−0.016 (0.011)	
Latino	0.005 (0.012)		−0.004 (0.012)	
Seniority	0.001 (0.001)		−0.001 (0.001)	
Majority Party	−0.016** (0.007)		−0.033*** (0.007)	
Republican	0.100*** (0.009)		0.045*** (0.009)	
Constant	0.367*** (0.020)		0.638*** (0.018)	
Observations	14,846	14,846	14,846	14,846
Member-Congress Random Effects	✓		✓	
Member-Congress Fixed Effects		✓		✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Models are estimated using OLS. Standard errors in the fixed-effects models are clustered by member. Fractional logit specifications for the fixed-effects models are available in the Appendix and produce statistically and substantively similar results. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

I Replication Using Homogeneous Policy Domains

Table I.1: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through, More Homogeneous Policy Areas

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent Variable:
	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.017* (0.010)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.017* (0.010)
Observations	7,980
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: OLS models with member-Congress-policy observations. Bipartisan bill engagement measures the proportion of bipartisan bills sponsored or cosponsored by a legislator. Models are limited to the following policy domains: *Agriculture, Defense, Education, Energy, Immigration, International Affairs, and Transportation*. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table I.2: Bipartisan Legislative Follow-Through by Type of Bipartisan Engagement, Homogeneous Policy Areas

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	DV: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor
No Bipartisan Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.018 (0.015)	−0.016 (0.012)
No Messaging vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	−0.041** (0.016)	−0.025* (0.013)
Observations	7,945	7,959
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: OLS models with member-Congress-policy observations. Models are limited to the following policy domains: *Agriculture, Defense, Education, Energy, Immigration, International Affairs, and Transportation*. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

J Salient Constituencies and Bipartisan Engagement

We note that bipartisan bill engagement is not distributed randomly across the policy agenda. Instead, it tends to occur on issues that matter to a legislator's constituents. To offer suggestive evidence, we predict the proportion of bipartisan bill activity in a policy area as a function of the proportion of a district belonging to a constituency with a substantive interest in that area. We focus on four policy areas and salient constituencies: agriculture and the proportion of agricultural workers; defense and the proportion of veterans; education and the proportion of enrolled college students; and social welfare and the proportion of residents aged 65 and above. These constituency proportions are calculated using totals taken from the 5-year American Community Survey (ACS) Census sample. While this analysis is intentionally narrow, Table J.1 shows a statistically significant bivariate relationship between bipartisan behavior on an issue and the share of a district's population belonging to the corresponding salient group.

Table J.1: Salient Constituencies and Bipartisan Bill Engagement Across Policy Areas

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Proportion of Substantive Agriculture	Bipartisan Defense	Bill Engagement Education	Social Welfare
Proportion Salient Population in District	4.928*** (1.321)	3.646** (1.690)	7.597** (3.075)	2.383* (1.344)
Constant	-1.216*** (0.217)	0.403*** (0.097)	-1.398*** (0.176)	-1.306*** (0.221)
Observations	1,302	1,302	1,302	1,302

Note: Model specification is a fractional logit. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

References

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